

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a website about email:

Why Are Young People Abandoning Email?

Having an email account used to be cool. You could send people in Africa your thoughts on a new K-Pop song, receive email confirmation for movie tickets you bought on the phone and ignore scam messages. Not anymore. Why? New York Times technology writer Matt Richtel has a theory – email just isn't cool anymore. An email account in the year 2014 is a "sign you're old. It's the technology your Dad uses". And, as we all know, the last thing a teenager wants to be is like his Dad. It also requires a "boringly long process of signing into an account, typing out a subject line and then sending a message that might not be received or answered for hours".

Teens, needless to say, do not have time for this sort of nonsense. As Ken Kampu, a 17-year-old student from Nairobi writes, "I don't use email for casual correspondence, why would I? It's too formal and unnecessary, it would be like writing your friend a long letter asking if they wanted to get coffee next Tuesday." Which is probably why, as Richtel notes, the "number of visitors in the United States to major e-mail sites like Yahoo! and Hotmail is now in steady decline, peaking as long ago as November 2009".

Yahoo! Senior Director of Product Management David McDowell, however, points out many email functions (attachments, cc lines) are not designed for teenagers anyway. Maybe they'll come around when they enter the workplace.

You are preparing to give a talk in your school to school leavers about writing emails in their lives after leaving school. You may want to talk about:

- whether young people write emails in their daily lives
- the challenges young people may face when writing formal emails
- the advantages of using email over other forms of communication
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you write emails often?
2. Do you find writing emails easy or difficult?
3. What is the most popular way for young people to communicate with each other?
4. Do you prefer writing an email or writing a letter?
5. What is the hardest thing about writing a formal email?
6. What kinds of letters cannot be replaced by emails?
7. Why do you think emails have replaced letters?
8. Do you agree that using emails is a sign that you are old?